Corpus Linguistics

Reading argument 2

Name: _____ ID: _____

In Oshita (2000), the distinction between Adjectival Passives (stative/resultative) and Verbal Passives (eventive/dynamic) is largely taken for granted; the definitions are given below:

- **Verbal Passive (Dynamic / Eventive)**: Describes an action or event initiated by an agent.
  [1] The door was closed by John at 5:00.
- A**djectival Passive (Stative / Resultative)**: Describes a state or property resulting from a prior action, functioning like a predicate adjective.
  [2] The door was closed when I arrived.

However, because both constructions share the surface structure *be + past* participle, second language learners and native speakers (sometimes, even advanced linguists) can easily confuse them. To distinguish between these two interpretations scientifically, linguists do not rely on subjective intuition. Instead, we use **linguistic diagnostic tests**—controlled tests based on grammatical behavior.

Question 1 One prominent diagnostic is the Degree Modifier Test (The *Very* Test). While the adverb very modifies adjectives to indicate degree (*happy → very happy*), it cannot directly modify verbs (*He was hit → *He was very hit*). Using this test, consider the following sentences with the participle *limited*. Which of the following is an example of an adjectival passive? Also provide the test sentences.

_____

(A) The seating capacity of the hall was **limited** by the new security rules.

→ _____

(B) Our seating capacity is **limited**, so please reserve your ticket early.

→ _____

(C) The budget was **limited** by the committee.

→ _____

(D) The speed was **limited** by the automated driver-assist system.

→ _____

Question 2 The progressive auxiliary (*be being* + *past participle*) forces a dynamic, ongoing event interpretation, so it is compatible only with verbal passives. By utilizing this diagnostic test as well as the Very test, we can detect an adjective passive. consider the following sentences and identify which option contains an adjectival passive.

_____

(A) The museum's main entrance was **decorated** with colorful flowers when the VIPs arrived.

→ _____

(B) The main entrance was **decorated** with colorful flowers, so the venue looked extremely festive.

→ _____

(C) The wooden door was **repaired** by a skilled carpenter throughout the entire morning.

→ _____

(D) The confidential document was **translated** into French during yesterday's session.

→ _____

Question 3 Regarding the L1 transfer account for *be+en* unaccusative errors, which statement accurately describes how empirical evidence shapes Oshita's evaluation?

(A) While compound tense transfer initially triggers these errors among European writers, its rapid disappearance in advanced stages shows that L1 influence is merely a temporary processing issue rather than grammatical.

(B) Although Asian L1 learners produce these errors, their significantly higher frequency among European L1 writers demonstrates that compound tense transfer remains the primary underlying cause across all L2 interlanguage grammars.

(C) Because native speakers of Asian languages express perfective aspect morphologically without auxiliary verbs, their unaccusative errors prove that L1 transfer operates indirectly through subtle semantic mapping rather than structural copying.

(D) Although the *be+en* structure strongly resembles compound tense/aspect systems in languages like French or German, the high frequency of these errors among Asian L1 learners (e.g., Japanese, Korean, Chinese) forces the rejection of the strong transfer hypothesis.

Question 4 Regarding the adjectival passive overgeneralization account, which statement correctly identifies its supporting observation and the critical flaws highlighted by Oshita?

(A) The adjectival passive account logically explains why errors appear as short passives, but Oshita deems it weak because advanced L2 learners avoid attributive uses and errors express dynamic rather than stative meanings.

(B) The adjectival passive account effectively explains why learners attach agentive by phrases to unaccusative verbs, but Oshita rejects it because target English strictly prohibits adjectival passive formation from any intransitive verb category.

(C) The adjectival passive account successfully accounts for errors in low-proficiency writing, but Oshita considers it insufficient because advanced learners exclusively passivize inherently stative verbs like exist to explicitly mark non-agentive subject properties.

(D) The adjectival passive account neatly clarifies how L2 learners derive nonce causative verbs, but Oshita doubts its validity because participle forms like elapsed or fallen are absent from available target language input.